

THE BUILDING YEARS · 26–45

How do I carry what I've taken on?

By now the choosing has mostly been done. A trade, a place, perhaps a person; debts, dependants, a name that others rely on. The question of these years is no longer *which life?* but *how to carry this one* — and what carrying it well even means.

That sketch fits some lives and not others — people arrive here late, or twice, or never, and the load is not the same in every hand. These stages are lenses, not a timetable. Five forks define the terrain. None of them resolves; each is a tension you will hold, in your own proportions, for twenty years. The voices gathered in this chapter disagree about every one of them — which is exactly why they are worth mapping.



The road through the Building Years. Each fork glyph marks a tension mapped in this chapter — **tendencies, never destinies.**

FORK ONE · CARRYING AND RELEASING

Do what is yours. Release the rest.

The heaviest loads of these years — the mortgage, the marriage, the child, the work — are exactly the ones whose outcomes you least control.

Voices centuries apart — some plausibly independent, one likely inheriting — arrive at a similar division of labour.

There are things which are within our power, and there are things which are beyond our power. Within our power are opinion, aim, desire, aversion, and, in one word, whatever affairs are our own.

— Epictetus (recorded by Arrian), Enchiridion 1 · trans. Thomas Wentworth Higginson

It is not for thee to finish the work, nor art thou free to desist therefrom

— Rabbi Tarfon, Pirkei Avot (Mishnah) 2:16 · trans. Charles Taylor (Sayings of the Jewish Fathers)



Solid lines: **partial argued independence**. Dashed: **lineage** — an idea that travelled, a different fact from one rediscovered. Convergence is robustness, not truth.

FORK ONE · THE ENGINE UNDERNEATH

The weight is partly a verdict

Underneath the division of labour sits a stranger claim: much of what crushes is not the event but the verdict we pass on it. Marcus Aurelius, to himself:

Take away thy opinion, and then there is taken away the complaint, "I have been harmed." Take away the complaint, "I have been harmed," and the harm is taken away.

— Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 4.7 (cf. 4.3: 'The universe is transformation: life is opinion') · trans. George Long

WISDOM NODE · PRUDENTIAL · CONDITIONAL

Much disturbance comes from our judgments, not the events themselves — drop the judgment and the harm loses its grip. This is counsel for the weight you carry anyway; it does not cover abuse, material injury, or preventable institutional harm.

Marcus Aurelius

Meditations 4.7 · trans. Long 1862

Withdraw the opinion of harm, he tells himself, and the complaint falls with it — and with the complaint, the harm.

Epictetus

Enchiridion 1 · trans. Higginson 1865

The parent claim: the Enchiridion lists opinion first among the things within our power — before aim, before desire — and Marcus's counsel supplies its engine.

Where it bends · Taken neat, it curdles into gaslighting yourself — some complaints are true. And the strict two-way split is contested, even by friends of the school: much of life is neither ours nor not-ours, but partly influenced.

text checked to George Long 1862 · 1 source voice behind this claim in the corpus · see where it bends

A wisdom-node card: one claim, its voices, where it bends, and an honest trust label.

FORK TWO · AMBITION AND PEACE

The wager and the desperation

Goethe's Faust stakes his soul on never being satisfied — the moment he bids any instant linger, he is forfeit. Pact-terms spoken by a complicated man whom the drama finally saves; a warning shape, not counsel.

Thoreau and Pascal chart the other ditch — though their ditches differ: one is resignation wearing routine, the other a life spent preparing to live.

The mass of men lead lives of quiet desperation.

— Henry David Thoreau, Walden 'Economy'

So we never live, but we hope to live; and, as we are always preparing to be happy, it is inevitable we should never be so.

— Blaise Pascal, Pensées Lafuma 47 / Sellier 80 / Brunschvicg 172 · trans. W. F. Trotter

Striving

curdles into Faust's
forfeit — a life spent
arriving, never living

curdles into quiet
desperation — resignation
wearing peace's clothes

Contentment

The answer is a position, moved as life moves — and the ditches have more than one shape: compulsive striving, quiet resignation, perpetual deferral.

A trade-off spectrum in **equal-status colour** — **neither pole is the wiser one here**. Both are goods; both curdle. Where you stand is a decision that **tends** to be re-made each decade, and this corpus holds honest voices for every position.

An older voice refuses both ditches. Facing the same restlessness, Qoheleth counsels neither wager nor surrender but the ordinary table: take honest joy in food, drink, and the work of your hands, in the face of impermanence.

Ask of your striving what it is for; ask of your peace what it is avoiding.

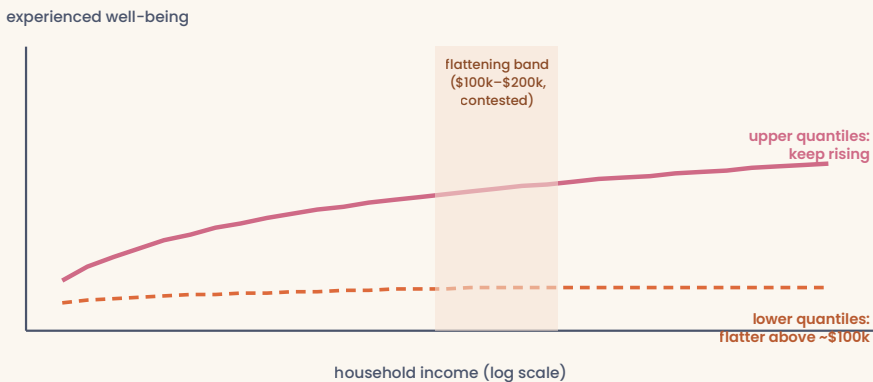
FORK TWO · WHAT THE STUDIES SAY ABOUT MONEY

What money tracks — a contested association

Schopenhauer's side of the fork claims that happiness rests on what one is, not what one has:

We have already seen, in general, that what a man is contributes much more to his happiness than what he has, or how he is regarded by others. [...] The most general survey shows us that the two foes of human happiness are pain and boredom.

— Arthur Schopenhauer, *Aphorisms on the Wisdom of Life* (Parerga und Paralipomena) ch. 2, 'Personality, or What a Man Is' · trans. T. Bailey Saunders



Schematic curves — one model's direction, not plotted data; competing analyses place the flattening differently (below). In the 2023 adversarial collaboration (Killingsworth, Kahneman & Mellers), all assessed quantiles of experienced well-being rise with log-income up to about \$100k; above it, the **lower conditional quantiles** stop rising significantly — a widening of the distribution, **not an identified group of unhappy people**. Rohrer & Wenz (2024) argue that reading it as a subgroup imports inappropriate causal assumptions; Bennedsen (2024) locates the plateau nearer \$200k. The data are observational.

Association, not destiny.

The data settle something narrow: a flat *money doesn't matter* reading fails — well-being tracks log-income. They do **not** test Schopenhauer's comparative claim that what one is matters more than what one *has*; nothing here weighs character or relationships against money. Where the slope flattens, and whether money *causes* it, both remain open.

FORK THREE · TIME, THE SCARCE THING

Two counsels for the same hour

Seneca's diagnosis stands at the head of the fork: it is not, he argues in *On the Shortness of Life*, that we are given too little time — it is that we waste so much of what we are given.

In the years when time becomes the scarce input of everything else, two counsels flatly disagree about what to do with the hour in front of you.

Seize the present

In the moment of our talking, envious time has ebb'd away. Seize the present; trust to-morrow e'en as little as you may.

— Horace, *Odes (Carmina)* 1.11.8 · trans. John Conington

SPEAKS TO

the postponer — the one whose real life is always scheduled for later

TRUSTS

today; almost nothing else

CURDLES INTO

a life of small immediacies that never builds anything

TAKE IT WHEN

your plans have quietly become the place you hide

Horace and Vauvenargues cannot both be followed in the same breath — a genuine fork about the horizon of the hour in front of you, and this book does not resolve it. The **speaks to / take it when** rows are editorial prompts — this book's hypotheses, not sourced findings; choosing is still yours.

Work as if deathless

To accomplish great things we must live as though we had never to die.

— Luc de Clapiers, marquis de Vauvenargues, *Réflexions et maximes* maxime 142 · trans. Elizabeth Lee

SPEAKS TO

the builder — work that outlasts a season needs a horizon longer than one

TRUSTS

the long arc; compounding; the unfinished

CURDLES INTO

precisely the postponement Seneca condemns

TAKE IT WHEN

the work is worth more than the mood of the week

Every purchase is priced in hours of your one life — count them before you spend, on either counsel. (After Thoreau.)

FORK FOUR · THE WEIGHT THAT STRENGTHENS?

Does the load make you stronger?

One of the oldest consolations this corpus holds says the load itself teaches — printed here *with its asterisk*, because the evidence cuts both ways.

WISDOM NODE · CONTESTED · PRINTED WITH ITS ASTERISK

Suffering can strengthen and can teach — sometimes, for some; and self-reports of growth run ahead of what studies can measure.

Aeschylus' chorus

Agamemnon 176–183 · trans. Smyth

Suffering as the fixed road to understanding — sung by a chorus inside a cycle of vengeance that only a court, at the trilogy's end, brings to a halt.

Nietzsche

Twilight of the Idols · trans. Ludovici

The blow that fails to kill can strengthen — restricted, in his own later gloss, to those already healthy enough to turn the blow to advantage.

Where it bends · Neither voice reached the thought independently — the philologist read the tragedian. Lineage, not convergence. Quoted alone, either voice claims more than its own story supports — that is the asterisk.

WHAT THE STUDIES ADD

- In a two-month prospective study (n = 122 undergraduates who reported a trauma between waves), retrospectively reported growth corresponded poorly with measured pre-to-post change (Frazier 2009) — a measurement caution, not a verdict on every survivor's report.
- Across 54 studies of varied stressors, the most common trajectory was resilience — staying near baseline, as each study defined it — not growth and not collapse (about two-thirds; Galatzer-Levy, Huang & Bonanno 2018).

texts checked (Smyth · Ludovici) · claim contested — the evidence cuts both ways · print only with this asterisk

FORK FIVE · THE HELP THAT FREES

Raising others without owning them

The Building Years are the raising years.

Two voices, eight centuries apart — a shared scriptural background is possible, but no documented link joins them — both refuse the easy, warm-feeling gift, though they aim at different targets.

There are eight levels of tzedakah, each one greater than the other. The greatest level, higher than all the rest, is to fortify a fellow Jew and give him a gift, a loan, form with him a partnership, or find work for him, until he is strong enough so that he does not need to ask others [for sustenance].

— Maimonides (Moses ben Maimon), Mishneh Torah, Hilkhoh Mattenot Aniyim 10:7 · trans. Joseph B. Meszler · trans. Joseph B. Meszler, CC BY 4.0, via Sefaria

love in action is a harsh and dreadful thing compared with love in dreams. ... active love is labor and fortitude, and for some people too, perhaps, a complete science.

— Fyodor Dostoevsky, The Brothers Karamazov Book II, ch. 4 'A Lady of Little Faith' (Zosima to Madame Khokhlakova; Garnett spells her 'Hohlakov') · trans. Constance Garnett

Maimonides ranks the gift that strengthens — the loan, the partnership, the job that ends the asking — above every warmer-feeling kind; anonymity marks a separate rung below.

Zosima aims elsewhere: at the giver's endurance — love as labour sustained without applause, against the quick, admired deeds of love in dreams.

An analogy joins them — both refuse help that flatters the helper — but they are cousins, not one claim, and they test your help in two different places.

Two tests for your help: what it leaves the other able to do — and what it asks of you when nobody claps.

THE BUILDING YEARS · A QUIET CLOSE

The unhistoric years

Most of what these two decades build will never be visible. No map of a life should pretend otherwise — or pretend it matters less for that.

George Eliot closes *Middlemarch* with this sentence — the narrator's last word on Dorothea Brooke, whose ardent nature never found the epic outlet it was built for.

But the effect of her being on those around her was incalculably diffusive: for the growing good of the world is partly dependent on unhistoric acts; and that things are not so ill with you and me as they might have been, is half owing to the number who lived faithfully a hidden life, and rest in unvisited tombs.

— George Eliot, *Middlemarch* Finale (final sentence)

The sentence has been read as consolation and as quiet protest at a society that wasted her; the Finale holds both readings open, and this book does not close them.

To this book's editorial eye — a judgment, not a finding — it is the Building Years' truest sentence: the work was not required to be finished, and it was not put down.